The Book That Saved the Earth

The big idea

The Book That Saved the Earth by **Claire Boiko** is a humorous science-fiction **play**. In the twenty-fifth century, a **Historian** tells how a book of nursery rhymes — **Mother Goose** — saved the Earth from a **Martian invasion** in the twentieth century. It pokes fun at false wisdom and shows the power of books.

Characters

Character	Role
Historian	narrator from the 25th century, in the Museum of Ancient History
Think-Tank	the arrogant, boastful ruler of Mars, with an enormous dome-shaped head; calls himself the "most brilliant intellect in the solar system"
Noodle	Think-Tank's **apprentice**; humble and in fact the wisest Martian
Captain Omega	commander of the space probe to Earth
Lieutenant Iota and **Sergeant Oop**	crew members

Summary

1. **The Historian** explains that the twentieth century was the "Era of the Book", when books held all kinds of information. Then he describes the Martian

invasion attempt.

2. **The landing:** Captain Omega, Iota and Oop land in **Centerville, USA**, inside a **public library**. They report to Think-Tank, who says the building is a "warehouse" and the books are "sandwiches".
3. **Eating books:** Think-Tank orders them to **eat** the books. Oop tries and hates it. Noodle consults the Universal Dictionary and suggests books are for **reading**.
4. **Reading Mother Goose:** They pick up a book of nursery rhymes and read aloud. Think-Tank interprets each rhyme foolishly:
   - **"Hey diddle diddle, the cow jumped over the moon"** → Earthlings have trained their cows to fly to the moon; their space programme is advanced.
   - **"Mistress Mary, quite contrary… silver bells and cockle shells"** → Earthlings grow **ammunition** (bells, shells) in their gardens.
   - **"Humpty Dumpty sat on a wall… had a great fall"** → Think-Tank realises the picture of an egg-shaped figure looks like **him** and thinks it is a plot to destroy the Martian ruler.
5. **The retreat:** Terrified, Think-Tank orders the invasion cancelled and the Martians to **evacuate Mars** and flee to a distant place (Alpha Centauri). The Historian concludes that the Earth was saved by a humble book of nursery rhymes — **Mother Goose** — and that the Martians and Earthlings later came to know each other in friendship.

THE HUMOUR

The "great intellect" Think-Tank misreads children's rhymes as military secrets — the humour lies in his **arrogance and ignorance**, while humble Noodle is wise.

WHO MISREADS THE BOOK

It is **Think-Tank**, not Noodle, who makes the absurd interpretations. Noodle is the sensible one.

Themes and value points

- **Arrogance leads to foolishness**; real wisdom is humble.
- The **power of books** and reading.
- Misinterpretation and fear can stop a war — and friendship is better than conquest.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why is the twentieth century called the "Era of the Book"? How did Think-Tank interpret the nursery rhymes? Why did he order a retreat? Compare Think-Tank and Noodle. How did the book "save" the Earth?

Quick recap

- Claire Boiko; a play; Historian narrates from the 25th century.
- Martians land in Centerville library; Think-Tank calls books "sandwiches".
- Mother Goose rhymes misread: cow over moon, Mistress Mary's garden, Humpty Dumpty.
- Think-Tank panics and orders a retreat; Earth is saved.

Practice questions

1. Who is the narrator of the play?
   (a) Think-Tank (b) Noodle (c) The Historian (d) Captain Omega
2. What did Think-Tank first think the books were?
   (a) Weapons (b) Sandwiches (c) Maps (d) Money
3. Which book did the Martians read?
   (a) A dictionary (b) A science textbook (c) A history of Mars (d) Mother Goose nursery rhymes
4. Why was Think-Tank frightened by "Humpty Dumpty"?
   (a) He was afraid of walls (b) He thought the egg-shaped figure who fell was a plot against him (c) He disliked eggs (d) He could not read the words
5. Who was Noodle?
   (a) A spaceship (b) An Earthling child (c) The Historian's assistant (d) Think-Tank's apprentice
6. According to Think-Tank, "Mistress Mary's garden" showed that Earthlings
   (a) grow flowers (b) grow ammunition (bells and shells) in their gardens (c) have pretty maids (d) have no water
7. Compare the characters of Think-Tank and Noodle.

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. d 4. b 5. d 6. b 7. see notes